POEM: BAYONET CHARGE

Suddenly he awoke and was running- raw

***Alliteration** of R and H sounds gives sense of hard work heavy breathing.*

In raw-seamed hot khaki, his sweat heavy,

***Contrast** between warzone and the 'green hedge' which is quite a peaceful rural image.*

Stumbling across a field of clods towards a green hedge

***Enjambment** adds to the chaos of the battlefield.*

That dazzled with rifle fire, hearing

***Personified** bullets and **semantic** body parts with 'belly' and 'smashed arm' blurs the line between weapon and man by **dehumanising** the soldier and personifying the weapons.*

Bullets smacking the belly out of the air -

He lugged a rifle numb as a smashed arm;

The patriotic tear that had brimmed in his eye

***Juxtaposed** ideas of patriotic tear, a beautiful and noble thing full of emotion contrasted with 'sweating like molten iron' which further **dehumanises** the soldier and likens him more to a tank or machine.*

Sweating like molten iron from the centre of his chest, -

In bewilderment then he almost stopped -

***Clockwork,** A metaphor for his actions as being more like a clockwork machine than human. **Trivialises** war to a game of toy clockwork soldiers between nations.*

In what cold clockwork of the stars and the nations

Was he the hand pointing that second? He was running

***Rhetorical Question,** marks the change of pace, it is as if this is happening in slow motion or the soldier has stopped as he thinks on what he has become.*

Like a man who has jumped up in the dark and runs

***Enjambment,** over four verses implies he has suddenly come to some realisation and this both seems to drag on but also all happen at once.*

Listening between his footfalls for the reason

Of his still running, and his foot hung like

Statuary in mid-stride.Then the shot-slashed furrows

Metaphor,** is it a real hare? Maybe a coward? Yellow is the colour of fear and hares are prey. Natural and frightened image **juxtaposed** with his own machine like nature. Possible that the hare is another soldier shot and scared, trying to escape. **Dehumanised.

Threw up a yellow hare that rolled like a flame

And crawled in a threshing circle, its mouth wide

Open silent, its eyes standing out.

***'plunges'** implies diving in too deep or cannot return. He has made his decision to carry on and there is no turning back.*

He plunged past with his bayonet toward the green hedge,

King, honour, human dignity, etcetera

***Listing** of the key motivations for war emphasises that here and now they are second to the rush of battle.*

Dropped like luxuries in a yelling alarm

***Atmospheric** description, similar to 'the air was electric', the word 'crackling' gives an element of danger to the verse.*

To get out of that blue crackling air

His terror's touchy dynamite.

***Metaphor** and **Consonance** of T sounds emphasises adrenaline rush and almost animal like reactions (Think of a cat that is prepared to fight or flee).*

Ted Hughes

If you want to help your understanding you could:

-See if you can find some good clips about charging into a fight, although it is not the same war 'Saving Private Ryan' really captures the pace and confusion (warning it is very violent).

-Consider how animalistic or mechanical the soldier is described, he is torn between man and nature, put the revelent quotes into a table.

Context:

The poem is about a nameless soldier going over the top in the trenches. Soldiers would have bayonets attached to the end of their rifles and would use them to stab enemy soldiers. The nameless soldier in the poem seems to become more a weapon than a man, rushing toward the enemy. It is not clear at the end whether he dies but there is definitely a change in him. His actions are very raw and primal, much like an animal, suddenly pausing, preparing to react. The poet, Ted Hughes, was a former RAF serviceman and includes a great amount of natural and historical ideas in his poems and he often looks at man's impact on nature.

Soldiers bayonet training

Themes:

The poem clearly is set around conflict in that it is a soldier rushing out of the trenches on the attack. However the poem also looks at ideas like transformation, humanity and nature (in the form of the yellow hare and green hedge). In the poem the solider is almost more machine or animal than human and this is reflected in the power themed words used to describe him.

Structure:

There are **three stanzas** and the work is largely **blank verse** with no set structure. In part the different lines help show the pace of the charge, sometimes fast, sometimes stumbling. Towards the end it picks up speed, perhaps as he approaches his destination or doom. The poet uses a lot of **enjambment** and **caesuras** to give a bizarre and erratic speed to the poem. This helps again give a structure to the speed of the charge but also the confusion and intensity of the battle with explosions and gunfire as well as the jumbled thoughts of the soldier.

Man or Mouse (Hare?):

There are parts of this poem which make us think more of a hunt or animals than humanity. The charge to the 'green hedge' seems to be more the action of an animal bolting in a field rather than soldiers charging a trench. The inclusion of the yellow hare is also powerful, we see the soldier in a moment of confusion, not sure why he is there and what he is doing, the hare seems to spur him on, either because he does not want to be a coward or because it reflects a brief moment of man and nature connecting before war once again breaks it.

A Hare

By the end of this you should know:

Higher Marks	Lower Marks
-The poem explores a soldiers charge through a mix of physical and emotional exploration.	*-The poem is about a soldier going over the trenches to attack.*
-The language of the poem seems to juxtapose natural animal images and human machine, they are at conflict.	*-There is a mix of language which talks about the soldier as a machine but also being quite like an animal.*
-The mix of caesura and enjambment in the poem adds a chaotic tone to show the confusion of war and the inner turmoil of the soldier.	*-The structure of the poem is a mix of fast and slow to show the confusion of fighting.*

Space for your notes: